

How exactly does AI use so much water and is all AI use equally bad for the environment?

Posted by u/Xx_calpal_xx • 0 points • 54 comments

I never understood how AI uses water/drinking water to run or if it's all equally as bad, like a simple question vs generating a picture/video. I started using ChatGPT little over a year ago and after realizing my increasing frequency I tried to avoid using it as much. But there are some things that it's been very helpful with that regular search engines couldn't match.

What it's helped the most with is learning more about my ancestry. I've been at a dead end for a few years, unable to find more info for my 2nd great-grandparents who immigrated here. ChatGPT was able to help me find the exact town in now Czechia they came from, gave me sites outside of U.S. to search for their church records, and translate the near impossible to read old German kurrent script with only a few potential mistakes that I'm working to correct myself.

If I didn't turn to AI to help, I wouldn't have figured out where they lived, known about the sites it gave me or how to navigate through the foreign language, and would've never found my 3rd and 4th great-grandparents. I don't want to overly use something that could be so harmful to the environment, but if this kind of usage isn't nearly as harmful it'd be great to keep it as a backup tool.

Comments

u/theofficialnova • -4 points • 2026-02-26 09:05 UTC

AI has an environmental footprint, like any computing. But the claim that "AI inherently wastes massive water" is often an oversimplified scare statistic. And more importantly, **AI can be environmentally beneficial overall** because it enables efficiency gains in energy, transport, industry, buildings, and science—areas where the biggest climate and resource wins actually are.

u/Outlaw1607 • 3 points • 2026-02-26 09:33 UTC

How would it do that?

u/theofficialnova • -2 points • 2026-02-26 09:39 UTC

It's not a serious answer, I just saw it fitting to ask AI to refute this claim and present AI as good for the environment

u/cardboard-kansio • 3 points • 2026-02-26 05:53 UTC

As mentioned, computers generate heat. ChatGPT and similar LLMs are just large farms of computers in a datacenter, and they use water for heat exchange cooling.

When you send a request to the LLM, it has to calculate a response. The more complex the request, the more calculation is needed over a longer time - which is why generating a picture is more intensive than a trivial text response. Imagine sending an email on your laptop compared to playing a AAA game for hours. The overall heat (and water) difference probably isn't all that much from just your one query, but it adds up eventually.